NGS

The Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) is set to make history, bringing *The Phantom of the Opera*, to India for the first time (March 5-30). This follows the success of *The Sound of Music*, *Mamma Mia!*, and *Matilda the Musical*, reinforcing NMACC's mission to present world-class productions to Indian audiences.

Founder and chairperson Nita Ambani describes *Phantom...* as a story that "unveils the beauty in vulnerability and the power of love that transcends barriers". She emphasises that NMACC's vision has always been to bring the finest performances to India, and as the centre approaches its second anniversary, this production is another extraordinary milestone.

Since its premiere in 1986, *The Phantom of the Opera* has captivated over 160 million people in 195 cities worldwide. Now, Indian audiences will experience the haunting tale of the Phantom, his obsession with soprano Christine Daaé, and the grandeur of the Paris Opera House brought to life on stage.

THE PHANTOM OF THE OPERA will be playing at the NMACC's Grand Theatre in Mumbai from March 5-30

Jonathan Roxmouth, who plays the Phantom, acknowledges the weight of taking on such an iconic role. "So many people have ownership of the character because of their love for the show and its music. The expectation is enormous," he says. "For me, the Phantom is a wounded child who never grew up after being abandoned. His intentions are pure, but his execution is tragic."

Associate director Rainer Fried, who has been instrumental in adapting the show for Mumbai, believes this marks a defining moment for musical theatre in India. "It's hard to believe that after all these years, *The Phantom...* is still making history," he says. "No other musical has defied cultural and sociological change the way Phantom has. We are confident it will capture the hearts of Indian audiences as it has done worldwide."

With its state-of-the-art facilities, the Grand Theatre at NMACC provides an ideal setting for the show's lavish production. "We don't expect to make any major changes," Fried explains. "The theatre is beautifully designed, and Phantom will look magnificent in this space."

Music supervisor Kristen Blodgette and associate choreographer Denny Berry have worked tirelessly to ensure the production seamlessly inhabits the Grand Theatre's stage. "We will transform the space into the Paris Opera House of the 1860s," they share. "Maria Björnson's gold proscenium blends every theatre into the period of the story. The opulent drapes, detailed costumes and intricate props bring the era alive."

At the heart of the story is Christine Daaé, a young singer navigating love, ambition and fear. Grace Roberts, who plays Christine, finds the character inspiring. "She is complex, and her journey—dealing with loss, sudden success and personal growth—is something audiences connect with," she says. Though set in the Victorian era, Roberts believes Christine embodies timeless values. "In our production, she is stronger and more ahead of her time than ever before. I hope Indian audiences relate to her growth, compassion and the way she moves people with her story."

With its breath-taking set design, unforgettable music and timeless story, *The Phantom of the Opera* at NMACC promises to be a landmark cultural event in India. ■

–Nikhil Sardana









MALLIKARJUN KATAKOL

THE LINE-UP (From left clockwise) Aruna Sairam; Ranjit Barot; Ravi Chary Crossing; Trilok Gurtu; SNAX

blending western jazz with Indian classical music. "Zakirji's influence remains a constant source of inspiration. This fusion represents his idea of seamlessly combining different musical traditions to create a rich, dynamic experience," says Chary.

The Thrillana Project, an ensemble of artistes along with Aruna Sairam, is also part of this year's edition. Conceived as a conversation across time, it aims to reimagine the traditional Thillana, exploring its inherent structure and rhythmic complexity, and weaving contemporary threads into it. "It is a delicate balance, honouring the sanctity of the classical form while allowing for the expression of modern sensibilities. It is, in a sense, a dialogue between the past and the present, a concept that resonates deeply with Zakir Hussain's own musical philosophy," explains Sairam.

Further, composer Ranjit Barot and theatre director Royston Abel will stage their musical production, *Beat-Route*. Other artistes performing at the festival include globally renowned virtuoso percussionist Trilok Gurtu and Chennai-based duo SNAX (Ramkumar Kanakarajan and Sumesh Narayanan). ■

–Neha Kirpal

(Mahindra Percussion Festival 2025 is on at the Prestige Centre of Performing Arts, Bengaluru, March 1-2)